

THE WRONG JESUS

When The Worship Is Right But The Jesus Is Wrong

A COMPANION GUIDE

For Personal Reflection or Small Group Study

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How to Use This Guide

Each chapter entry in this guide can be read alone, slowly, with a cup of coffee and a pen — or brought into a room with other people. The questions move from personal to shared: the first few are best answered quietly, in a journal, before you talk to anyone. The last few are built for a circle.

If you're using this guide on your own, work through all five questions at your own pace. If you're leading a group, feel free to pick two or three rather than working through the whole list — the goal is a real conversation, not a completed worksheet.

Each entry includes the chapter's key Scripture passage, a short devotional idea, a pull-quote from the book, five reflection questions, and a closing prayer. Use whatever pace fits your life — one chapter a day, one a week, or one per group session.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

Introduction

Read: *Mark 11:1–11*

THE IDEA

You can passionately worship the wrong Jesus. That is the warning this whole book is built around, and it starts in a mud-brick church in Tanzania where Bill couldn't understand a word being sung and still recognized it, unmistakably, as worship. Real worship and accurate worship are not automatically the same thing. The crowd on Palm Sunday proves it — present, passionate, quoting Scripture, and sincerely wrong.

Before you read Chapter One, sit with the question this whole book keeps circling back to.

SIT WITH THIS

“*Am I following Jesus, or am I following what I want Him to be?*”

CHAPTER ONE

The Parade We All Join

Read: Mark 11:1–10 · Zechariah 9:9

THE IDEA

Nobody comes to Jesus as a blank slate. Every person who has ever encountered Him has encountered Him through something — a tradition, a wound, a hope, a political moment — and most of the time we have no idea we’re doing it. The crowd on Palm Sunday carried four hundred years of Maccabean memory into that street, so when a king rode in on a donkey exactly as Zechariah had promised, they laid down palm branches for a warrior-king who was never coming.

Jesus was announcing exactly who He was. They were hearing exactly who they needed Him to be. Both things happened on the same road, on the same morning, and nobody could see the difference.

SIT WITH THIS

“The distance between the Jesus we expect and the Jesus who actually shows up is the space where most of our spiritual confusion lives.”

QUESTIONS TO SIT WITH

1. If someone had asked you to describe Jesus before you ever read a Bible for yourself, what would you have said — and where did that picture come from?
2. Sarah met Jesus as her healer and never learned to relate to Him any other way. What’s the one category you first met Jesus in that quietly became the only room in your faith you know how to stand in?
3. The palm branches aren’t in Zechariah — the crowd added something biblical and something cultural together without noticing the seam. Where might you be doing the same thing?
4. What’s a “four hundred years” in your own story — a wound, a season, a tradition — that shaped the lens you bring to Jesus even now?
5. Can you name a moment when the Jesus who actually showed up didn’t match the Jesus you expected?

PRAY

Lord Jesus, I don’t want the version of You I built. I want the One who is actually here. Amen.

CHAPTER TWO

The Jesus We Needed

Read: Mark 11:1–11 (continued)

THE IDEA

We don't shape Jesus out of dishonesty. We shape Him out of need. The Jesus of the wounded, the Jesus of the comfortable, the Jesus of the political — every wrong Jesus begins as a real and legitimate human need reaching toward God. That's what makes the mistake so hard to see in ourselves. It doesn't look like rebellion. It looks like faith.

The problem was never where these pictures of Jesus started. The problem is where we forced Him to stay.

SIT WITH THIS

“We don't shape Jesus out of dishonesty. We shape Him out of need.”

QUESTIONS TO SIT WITH

1. Of the three lenses named in this chapter — the wounded, the comfortable, the political — which one do you recognize most honestly in yourself?
2. What real need were you reaching for when you first came to faith? Has that need quietly become the whole shape of your relationship with Jesus?
3. A Jesus shaped around a wound eventually can't heal it. A Jesus shaped around comfort can't challenge you to grow. Which of those limits is currently active in your life?
4. Where have you watched someone else build a version of Jesus out of a legitimate need — and could you extend them the same grace you'd want extended to you?
5. What would it cost you to let Jesus be bigger than the role you've asked Him to play?

PRAY

Lord, You are not smaller than the version of You I built. Show me where I've limited You to what I needed, and give me the courage to want the real thing more than the comfortable one. Amen.

CHAPTER THREE

The Sincerity Trap

Read: *Matthew 7:21–23 · Galatians 1:13–14*

THE IDEA

Sincerity feels like a safeguard. It isn't. Paul was sincerely, zealously, violently wrong about Jesus before Damascus — advancing, devoted, and dangerous precisely because he cared so intensely. Jesus tells a crowd of people who prophesied and cast out demons in His name, “I never knew you.” Not a loss of relationship. A relationship that was never there.

The uncomfortable truth this chapter puts in front of us is that a person can be sincerely, lifelong devoted to a Jesus who is, at critical points, not the Jesus of Scripture — and sincerity alone will never correct that.

SIT WITH THIS

“Sincerity, by itself, is not a check on error but the fuel for it.”

QUESTIONS TO SIT WITH

1. Have you ever been completely sincere about something and completely wrong at the same time? What did it eventually take for you to see it?
2. Why is it more unsettling that Jesus said “I never knew you” to devout, active believers than to obvious hypocrites?
3. Where in your own faith life do you lean on how strongly you feel about something as proof that it's true?
4. Paul's sincerity didn't protect him — contact with the real Jesus is what corrected him. What would “contact with the real Jesus” look like for you this week, practically?
5. Where does your church culture (or your own habits) treat sincerity and truth as though they were the same thing?

PRAY

Jesus, I don't want to mistake how I feel about You for actually knowing You. Correct me where my sincerity has outrun my accuracy. Amen.

CHAPTER FOUR**When Jesus Doesn't Do What You Hired Him For****Read:** Mark 11:11–17**THE IDEA**

Jesus rides in to the loudest welcome Jerusalem has ever staged, walks into the temple, looks around, and goes to Bethany for the night. No confrontation. No declaration. Just dinner and sleep. When He finally does act the next day, He doesn't move against Rome — He moves against the temple, the one institution everyone assumed was already on God's side.

He didn't attack what the crowd wanted destroyed. He attacked what the crowd wanted protected. That inversion is the whole chapter: what we expect Jesus to do reveals what we believe His purpose in our lives actually is.

SIT WITH THIS

“He didn't attack what the crowd wanted to destroy; He attacked what the crowd wanted to protect.”

QUESTIONS TO SIT WITH

1. Marcus built his faith around Jesus-as-restorer, and when the pattern broke, he didn't lose his faith — he lost his Jesus. Has disappointment with God ever exposed what you'd actually built your expectations on?
2. What's the “temple” in your own life — the thing you'd assume is already safe from His correction?
3. When Jesus doesn't escalate the way you expect Him to, what's your first instinct — to defend your expectations, or to ask what they reveal?
4. Where have you experienced the gap between what you expected from God and what actually happened this year?
5. If Jesus walked into the part of your life you're most confident about and started clearing tables, what would He find?

PRAY

Lord, I bring You the places I've assumed are already sanctified. Show me where my confidence has become a closed door. Amen.

CHAPTER FIVE

The Jesus Who Tears Things Down

Read: Mark 13:1–2 · Luke 19:41

THE IDEA

There's a version of surrender most of us are willing to make — the obvious sins, the habits we already know are wrong. The harder surrender is the one Jesus actually asks for: the structure we're certain God approves of, the tradition we believe He ordained. Jesus predicts the temple's total destruction not out of indifference, but because what it pointed to had already arrived in the flesh.

He wept over the city even as He let the thing they loved most come down. The question this chapter asks isn't whether your tradition is bad. It's whether you're holding it with an open hand or a closed fist.

SIT WITH THIS

“The wrong Jesus will never ask you to open your fist. He'll never ask you to relinquish to Him that which you have built up for Him.”

QUESTIONS TO SIT WITH

1. Carol's crisis wasn't caused by sin — it was caused by a faith structure that couldn't survive her child's honest questions. Have you watched (or lived through) a structure like that crack?
2. Jesus wept over the very city whose temple He was about to let fall. How do grief and conviction hold together in that image, for you?
3. Are you holding your church, your theology, your tradition with an open hand or a closed fist?
4. What in your life would you resist surrendering to Jesus — and why do you consider it protected?
5. What would it look like to let God rebuild something in your faith that you've spent years defending?

PRAY

Lord, I don't want to protect a structure from You just because I built it in Your name. Give me the grace to stand in the rubble if that's where You're leading. Amen.

CHAPTER SIX

Going Somewhere You Didn't Sign Up For

Read: Mark 14:3–9 · Mark 10:33–34

THE IDEA

The disciples signed up for a coronation. They were being led toward a cross. Somewhere between Palm Sunday and Good Friday, following Jesus stopped matching the map most of them were carrying — and a woman with an alabaster jar understood the destination before any of the Twelve did. She anointed Him for burial while they were still debating seating arrangements in the kingdom.

Most of us carry a quiet contract: I'll follow, and in return the path will make sense. The real Jesus never signed that contract.

SIT WITH THIS

"The wrong Jesus will never take you somewhere that costs you anything you weren't already prepared to spend."

QUESTIONS TO SIT WITH

1. The woman with the alabaster jar saw where Jesus was headed before the disciples did. What did she see that they missed?
2. What's a "map" you've carried about where following Jesus is supposed to lead — and what happened when the road didn't match it?
3. "Obedience over comfort" is a phrase from Bill's own family. Where is that exact choice in front of you right now?
4. Have you ever caught yourself confusing following Jesus with consulting Him — treating discipleship like a contract you could review and approve?
5. Where is Jesus asking you to go right now that you've been resisting?

PRAY

Lord, I don't want to negotiate the terms of following You. Give me the willingness to keep walking when the road goes somewhere I didn't plan for. Amen.

CHAPTER SEVEN

Choosing Barabbas

Read: Mark 15:6–15

THE IDEA

The crowd didn't walk away from Jesus on Good Friday. They redirected their hope toward a substitute — a revolutionary with the right enemies and the wrong outcome. This is the most common and least visible failure in the whole book: when the real Jesus fails to deliver what our wrong Jesus promised, we rarely stop worshiping. We just start worshiping a stand-in and keep calling him by the same name.

It happens in ministry, in activism, in seasons of desperate need. It rarely announces itself as betrayal. It feels like holding out for the real thing.

SIT WITH THIS

“When the real Jesus fails to deliver what our wrong Jesus promised, we don't stop worshiping. We change who we are worshiping, and we call the substitute by the same name.”

QUESTIONS TO SIT WITH

1. What's your Barabbas — the substitute you've reached for when Jesus didn't deliver what you wanted?
2. Bill names three patterns: rescue-Jesus swapped for a financial fix, calling-Jesus swapped for ministry success, justice-Jesus swapped for a cause. Which one lands closest to home for you?
3. Why is this substitution so hard to see while it's happening — for the crowd, and for us?
4. Has a real disappointment with God ever been quietly redirected toward something else you started trusting instead?
5. What would it take for you to name your Barabbas out loud to someone else this week?

PRAY

Lord, show me where I've traded You for a substitute wearing Your name. I want the real thing, even when it costs me the illusion of control. Amen.

CHAPTER EIGHT

Loud Voices

Read: Mark 15:11

THE IDEA

Nobody builds their picture of Jesus alone. The chief priests stirred the crowd toward Barabbas — not gently, but with deliberate incitement — and the crowd never felt manipulated, because the anger felt entirely like their own. That’s how stirring works: the best version leaves no fingerprints.

We live in an era of unprecedented noise, and most people who consider themselves followers of Jesus are, in practice, followers of their favorite interpreter of Jesus. The correction isn’t complicated. It’s slower and costs more: read the Gospels directly, without a filter, until you’re surprised.

SIT WITH THIS

“Every layer of interpretation between you and the Word Itself is a layer of someone else’s potentially wrong Jesus standing between you and the real One.”

QUESTIONS TO SIT WITH

1. Whose voice has most shaped your picture of Jesus — and do you know what they were getting out of the version they handed you?
2. Where do you notice yourself being “stirred” — a feed, a podcast, a preacher — toward a conclusion that felt like it came from inside you?
3. When did you last read one of the Gospels directly, without a sermon, commentary, or clip shaping how you received it first?
4. What’s the difference, for you, between having teachers and only having teachers?
5. What would it look like to put the phone down this week and go to the source instead?

PRAY

Lord, quiet the loudest voices in my life long enough for me to hear Yours directly. I want to know You, not just know what someone else says about You. Amen.

CHAPTER NINE

The Quieter Sin

Read: Mark 15:1–15 (especially v. 10) · Matthew 27:19, 24

THE IDEA

Pilate is the most uncomfortable figure in the Passion story, not because he's the most villainous, but because he isn't. He sees exactly what's happening, says so out loud, and participates anyway. He had the authority to end the whole proceeding with one gesture. What he lacked was the will to use it.

He washes his hands publicly, not to convince himself, but to manage how the moment will be remembered. History assigned him the responsibility he tried to wash off. The failure this chapter names isn't ignorance or deception — it's knowing exactly what's right and finding sophisticated reasons not to do it.

SIT WITH THIS

“He handed the effective decision to the crowd... It was entirely his doing. Full stop.”

QUESTIONS TO SIT WITH

1. Pilate had the authority to stop the whole thing. What kept him from using it?
2. “Just-not-yet becomes never.” Where has that pattern shown up in your own life — a conversation, a decision, a boundary you've been circling instead of setting?
3. Have you ever performed the appearance of careful consideration as a way of avoiding an actual decision?
4. What is the one-on-one conversation you've been avoiding that you already know needs to happen?
5. What would it cost you to “wave your hand” on something you've been outsourcing to someone else's courage?

PRAY

Lord, give me the willingness to act on what I already know, instead of waiting for a clarity that may never come. Amen.

CHAPTER TEN**Jesus Has Never Been Ambiguous About Who He Is**

Read: Mark 11:1–11 (revisited)

THE IDEA

The book turns back to where it started, with different eyes. Jesus arranged the colt, the road, the timing — He wasn't swept along by anyone's enthusiasm. He was fulfilling a five-hundred-year-old prophecy in broad daylight, in front of thousands of people who had access to that same prophecy. He wasn't hiding. He wasn't sending mixed signals.

In a small, easily missed detail, He returned the borrowed colt on His way back to Bethany — the kind of quiet integrity that tells you who someone really is. The mistake has always been in reception, not in transmission.

SIT WITH THIS

“The mistake has always been in reception, not the transmission.”

QUESTIONS TO SIT WITH

1. Why does it matter that Jesus's entry into Jerusalem was planned and intentional rather than something He got swept into?
2. What does the detail of the returned colt tell you about who Jesus is in the small, unwitnessed places of your own life?
3. If the mistake has always been in reception, not transmission, how does that change the way you think about times you've misunderstood God?
4. Read the Gospel of Mark this week, as this chapter suggests, as if Jesus is trying to tell you exactly who He is. What surprised you?
5. Where might you be reading your own conclusions into Jesus instead of letting Him surprise you?

PRAY

Lord, I want to see You as You actually are, not as I've assumed You to be. Surprise me. Amen.

CHAPTER ELEVEN**The Disciples as Servants Who Simply Kept Walking**

Read: Mark 11:1–8 (revisited)

THE IDEA

The crowd is loud and monopolizes the scene. The disciples are quieter — two sent ahead for the colt, cloaks thrown across its back without being asked, a small group that walks into the city, into the temple, and back to Bethany without full understanding of any of it. They don't wait for comprehension before they obey.

That, more than any spiritual excellence, is the model this chapter offers: present, attentive, willing to move before they fully understand. The crowd celebrated Jesus for a morning. The disciples followed Him into the week.

SIT WITH THIS

“The palm branches came from the crowd’s emotional enthusiasm. The cloaks came from the disciples’ humble attention.”

QUESTIONS TO SIT WITH

1. The disciples threw their cloaks over the colt without being asked — a small, unasked-for act of attention. What's a quiet act of following you could offer this week, without waiting to be told?
2. “If we have to understand everything before we obey, we are not worshiping Jesus. We are worshiping our own understanding.” Where does that describe you?
3. What's the difference, practically, between celebrating Jesus and following Him?
4. Where have you found yourself in a “permanent holding pattern” — always processing, never quite arriving at the step?
5. What is Jesus asking you to do right now that you don't fully understand?

PRAY

Lord, I don't want to wait for full understanding before I obey. Give me the disciples' willingness to keep walking toward You. Amen.

CHAPTER TWELVE

You Cannot Surrender What You Have Not Named

Read: *The Wrong-Jesus Inventory (a set of self-examination questions, not a single narrative passage)*

THE IDEA

You cannot think your way out of a wrong Jesus. Understanding is necessary but not sufficient — the wrong Jesus lives in habits and instinctive responses to disappointment, not primarily in theology. This chapter is the naming chapter: five honest questions, not designed to produce shame, but clarity.

The questions that make you want to move on quickly are usually the ones most worth staying with. What follows the naming is not a technique but a practice — honest prayer, Scripture read for formation rather than ammunition, and community with people who don't share your blind spots.

SIT WITH THIS

“You cannot lay down what you have not identified.”

QUESTIONS TO SIT WITH

1. When Jesus disappoints you, what has He failed to do? Name the expectation underneath the disappointment as specifically as you can.
2. What in your life would you not want Jesus to touch?
3. Who gave you your picture of Jesus, and what were they getting out of the version they handed you?
4. Does your Jesus ever surprise you — or does He only ever confirm what you already believed?
5. What do you need or want Jesus to be that He has never actually claimed to be?

PRAY

Say the Prayer of Surrender from this chapter, in your own words, naming specifically what you've needed Jesus to be that He hasn't promised — and ask Him to show you who He actually is.

WHERE WE LAND

Conclusion

Read: *Psalm 118:25–26 (quoted in Mark 11:9–10)*

THE IDEA

The crowd on Palm Sunday wasn't wrong about everything. "Hosanna, blessed is He who comes in the name of the Lord" was theologically accurate — it was their imported expectations underneath the shout that bent Him into something He wasn't. That distinction is the mercy this book ends on: the construction of a wrong Jesus is not the opposite of faith. It's faith, filtered through our humanity, before it's been purified by encounter with the real thing.

You'll build a new wrong Jesus again — from new materials, in a new season. That's not a failure to overcome once. It's a question to keep engaging honestly, every time it resurfaces.

SIT WITH THIS

"The Jesus who exceeds your wrong version of Him is not a threat to your faith. He is the answer to it."

FINAL REFLECTION

Look back over all twelve chapters. Where did you find yourself most exposed? Where did you find the most hope? Carry the question forward:

"Am I following Jesus, or am I following what I want Him to be?"

PRAY

Lord Jesus, keep bringing me back to this question. I'd rather have the real You, uncomfortable as He sometimes is, than a comfortable substitute I built myself. Amen.